Transcript in English

The Open University. Digital Transformation and Skills

[Visual information: Different speakers in different settings are interviewed and address the camera in a medium shot.]

«OpenLearn. Free Learning from The Open University»

«Jessica Leigh Jones Mbe,
Chief Executive Officer, Iungo Solutions»

«Prif Swyddog Gweithredol, Iungo Solutions»

Jessica Leigh Jones Mbe:
The word “digital” has really evolved in terms of its meaning. So when I first came across the word “digital” as an engineer, I assumed that meant ones and zeros, binary... Now, “digital” has grown to have this much broader, much more holistic meaning about workflow and leadership and agile ways of working.

So when we think about standards in digital, I think it’s very easy to get caught up in the idea of using specific tools. And in our organisation, previously, we made the mistake of mandating certain tools. We don’t mandate what tools they use. So if they’re using an iPad, they might use Procreate. If they’re using a Windows machine, they might use Inkscape. And that’s fine as long as the format is the same.

But also, I think it’s less about the tool itself and more about the way that those tools are used. So, for example, mind mapping tools like Miro, Mural, Google Jamboard…, they are great for collaboration, but only if you put the preparation in to take your users through that journey. So the tool itself does not compensate for the workflow. The tool is part of the workflow.

There are three types of digital role within a modern organisation. So there are digital architects or digital leaders, and they are the people who really understand digital workflows, understand how to create and facilitate collaboration within the workforce.

Then you have your digital developers. So these are sort of the typical people that we think of when we talk about digital. These are your coders, your programmers, the people who develop the tools that we use to enable our organisations to become digital.

And then you have everybody else. Everybody else sits in that box of being a digital consumer. And so no matter what level, no matter what role, when you’re recruiting somebody into an organisation or you’re going through a digital transformation with your existing workforce, you have to think about those sort of basic level digital consumer skills that everybody needs.

«Gemma Hallet,
Head of Skills at Fintech Wales and Mifuture
Founder – Fintech Wales and Mifuture»

Gemma Hallet:
Technology is so different in the workplace. I see it all the time with our innovative startup high-growth fast moving companies, startups, exciting places to work [which] have the latest technology. And then I see maybe, for want of a better position… I'll pick the local authority. I've walked into council buildings where they're using big desktop monitors, a keyboard, a mouse… If that's the world of work these young people are going into, then that's a different skill set, especially digital skill set, than the ones for high fast growing, fast moving companies that are, I suppose, technology-wise and digital-wise.

But we're also seeing in the care sector as well. That's gone from writing down daily reports and leaving them in the kitchen, or … Especially in domestic care, where care workers have gone from using pen and paper, to now there's an iPad mounted there, and they're on to record everything digitally.

And the skill shortage there, when it comes to digital skills, it's huge. The training they have to do to bring somebody that's been in care for the last 10, 20, 30 years, to be able to use an iPad, and the apps that they use to monitor everything… That's the way the care sector's going, so that needs that skill set as well.

«Jonathan Morgan,
CEO – Object Matrix LTD
Prif Swyddog Gweithredol – Object Matrix LTD»

Jonathan Morgan:
It's very easy when you're in an education environment to play with a concept or a tool. But actually in the real world, what the customer wants is a rounded product, 100% working, without flaws, with documentation –that horrible word nobody likes–, but actually a product that's thought through from beginning to end.

And perhaps in education, as we do digital transformation, as we look at new technologies that can be used, it's also about the quality of delivery that ultimately customers will want to have in the real world.

New ways of working are phenomenal. Some of the productivity that comes out of new tools, some of the new things that are happening in my world and in asset management… How do you search a video? Can you search on people's faces? Can you search on the text? Can you have analysis of a video to know that's a car chase, that's say romantic scene, that something else happening and be able to search on that?

So some of the technologies that are coming up productivity-wise, functionality-wise, they are going to transform the way that data in the media industry is used, and that is so exciting.

«Dr. Becki Vickerstaff,
Higher Education Senior Consultant –Jsic
Uwch Ymgynghorydd Addysg – Jsic»

Dr. Becki Vickerstaff:
If we think outside of the education sector, initially, if we look at just our digital world, pretty much everything we need to do is needing to be done online. If we even think about paying our car tax, things like that, that requires us to be able to do these things online. So that initial… It's having that awareness of the appropriate technology and the appropriate techniques to be able to… Again, it's about thriving successfully in a digital world, but also that having that awareness of where our own digital capabilities lie is really important.

And I think with staff and students initially there is… I think there is a bit of a consensus, if you like, that when students come into the university they're very naturally digitally literate, if you'd like, that they're happy with it.., But whether that's necessarily true, I think what we have to understand is it's about the correct use of these digital technologies and it's about supporting staff and students.

So we're thinking about the digital needs of our students and our graduates as well when they go out into the workplace. The workplace is changing phenomenally at the moment in terms of the digital space, so we need to provide them with those transferable digital skills. And I think as technology is evolving so quickly, I mean, suddenly everyone is probably more aware of Teams than they were ever before, and Zoom.

So it's given us the idea that we need to be able to adapt for that. So we need to really embed that lifelong learning, embed the space to broaden those skills, and also to be able to learn them as well.

«Myles Ogilvie,
Principal – Sooner Safer Happier Limited
Pennaeth – Sooner Safer Happier Limited»

Myles Ogilvie:
The pandemic made it clear that every organisation is enabled by software. So whether you're a pub or you're a university or you are a school or you a business, software is making the difference between your ability to survive or fail. If you're a pub, being able to attract people during a pandemic to pick up shopping from your front door or for outside or somehow interact with your customers is equally important.

So software is eating the world. It's one of the phrases that are used. This has been true for many years. We are in the age of digital, and unlike in the age of mass production –where work was optimised around consistency and standardisation and output per minute–, with software, users don't know what they need until they see it, and everything is unique, and a different optimisation is needed.

What will digital transformation look like in the future? There are a few key things to bear in mind. Firstly, across industry, we see organisations really at the beginning of this journey. And so there is lots of change ahead of us, and it won't stop. It's not like there's a finite end point you get to, but there is a key shift going on at the moment.

And in making those shifts, we'd say, firstly, as a leader, you need to be thinking hard about the type of leadership on offer, getting clarity on purpose and challenging themselves how to evidence and detect success.

You need to think hard about your organisation structure. Are you optimised for the flow of value? Or are you in role-based silos still? And thinking hard about the system of work, how to really visualise from strategy through to execution, how to regularly re-prioritise based on knowledge and lessons that have been learned and pivoting to focus on the right thing.

«Natasha Davies,
Policy and Research Lead – Chwarae Teg
Arweinydd Polisi Ac Ymchwil – Chwarae Teg»

Natasha Davies:
So I think as businesses, but also from the government, we absolutely need to have investment in basic digital skills to make sure that everybody's got a good baseline. I think some organisations had to quite quickly during the pandemic adopt a far more digital first approach. We've seen sort of mass take up of systems like Teams, which are constantly evolving and changing as new features are rolled out to help collaborative working.

So I also think it goes beyond the sort of the basic digital skills and making sure that we're supporting staff and our workforce and our leaders to be confident in embracing and trying out new technology as it comes. It can't be a static thing.

So we're going to need to make sure that we're creating a culture in which constant learning is the norm and making sure that we've got the support measures in place, the training in place, to make sure that people are confident as new technology comes out −or changes to the technology we're using every day are coming out, because they come out faster than you can keep up with a lot of the time−.

I think we're going to need to make sure that leaders in particular have a good understanding about how different digital tools can be best used to support agile and inclusive ways of working. No one digital solution is going to offer everything that we need, so our leaders are going to have to really be confident in doing that and able to lead by example on that, because if you've got a leader who's very hesitant about new technology that's going to roll down into the way that teams are able to work.

«Elise Lockyer,
Chief People Officer – Sonovate Limited
Prif Swyddog Pobl – Sonovate Limited»

Elise Lockyer:
[Regarding] Digital transformation, if you ask me what's going to happen in the next five-ten years, I can't tell you. I couldn't have told you what would happen pre-pandemic. So the best skills that any individuals can have within an organisation or coming into employment for their first time is the desire to constantly learn, grow, develop, ask questions, stay curious, and be constantly open and driven to learn, grow and evolve their skills.

Of course, all the basic digital skills that children of today, adults of today, within a kind of professional working environment have are very important, but the ability and the openness and drive to develop those skills, learn more, adapt, grow are the soft skills that are going to enable you to enhance and drive yourself and businesses forward.